

Life Through the Spirit

Lesson 13 Questions

First Day: Read the Lesson 12 Notes.

The notes and lecture fortify the truth of the passage for understanding and application to daily life.

1. How did the lecture help you notice God's work in your life this week?

2. What truth from the notes helped you better understand believers' ongoing battle with sin?

Second Day: Read Romans 8:1-4.

Paul proclaimed that believers are free from sin's condemnation.

3. a. How does Paul's heart cry in Romans 7:24-25 lay the groundwork for His triumphant declaration in Romans 8:1?

   b. Define the following words:

   Therefore

   Now

   No

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Condemnation

c. What makes the proclamation of verse 1 especially significant to you?

4. a. From verses 2-3, describe the work of the Trinity (Father, Son, and Holy Spirit) to save sinners. (See also John 14:15-21; 16:8-15.)

b. Because those in Christ are no longer under the law, how and why do they fulfill the law's requirements?

5. What powerful truth from this passage impacts your life, and how will you express thanks to God?

Third Day: Read Romans 8:5-11.

Paul described two different mindsets.

6. Name the two different groups Paul described and contrast their minds and lives.

7. a. How do you recognize a mind set on the Spirit's desires? (See also Galatians 5:22-23; Colossians 3:1-4; and other verses you know.)

b. What desires of your mind and heart demonstrate that the Spirit of God lives in you?

8. According to verses 9-11, what things are true of everyone in whom the Spirit of God (also called the Spirit of Christ) lives, and how do these truths encourage you today?

Fourth Day: Read Romans 8:12-13.

Paul exhorted believers regarding a new obligation.

9. To what is a believer no longer obligated? What is the believer's new obligation, and why?

10. a. What does the phrase “put to death” teach about the attitude people should have toward sin? (See also 2 Corinthians 7:1; Philippians 3:10-14.)

    b. How is it possible to “put to death the misdeeds of the body”? (See also Romans 6:11-14; Galatians 5:13-21; Colossians 3:5-17.)

11. What challenges do you face living life according to the Spirit? How do you need the Holy Spirit’s help, and how can your group pray for you?

Fifth Day: Read Romans 8:14-17.

Paul explained believers’ new status with God.

12. What is a believer’s new status with God, and why is this a cause for celebration?

13. a. Read Matthew 6:7-8; 10:29-31; Romans 8:29; Hebrews 12:7-11; and 1 John 3:1-3. What are additional benefits of being God’s child?

    b. If you are a believer, express how you have experienced these benefits.

14. How might these truths help you or others who doubt God’s fatherly love?

Sixth Day: Review Romans 8:1-17.

The Holy Spirit empowers God’s children to live holy lives.

15. What was most meaningful to you in this week’s passage, and why?

Homiletics for Group and Administrative Leaders: Romans 8:1-17

Next step: Continue this lesson with group discussion, lecture, and notes.

Lecture Notes

Lesson 13 Notes

Romans 8:1-17

Focus Verse

"Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus." (Romans 8:1)

Outline

- Freedom in the Spirit – Romans 8:1-11
- Life in the Spirit – Romans 8:12-17

Engage

In the world today, people long for freedom they cannot secure for themselves. Some may suffer as actual prisoners of war or victims of human trafficking. Depression, physical limitations, illness, or emotional struggles hold others hostage. In the end, all people face a common challenge: sin's pull and condemnation. **God's people battle with sin, internally and externally, each day.** Paul lamented this reality in Romans 7:19: "For I do not do the good I want to do, but the evil I do not want to do—this I keep on doing." Do you relate to Paul? As he turned his pen toward the next chapter, Paul celebrated a dramatic truth that radically transformed his struggle.

Paul's first words in Romans 8 proclaim no condemnation, and his final words promise no separation. Between these two life-altering pillars of truth, Paul unfolded a panorama of how the triune God powerfully and permanently works to save and secure His people.

Believers no longer suffer God's wrath because, through Christ, the Holy Spirit frees them from the law of sin and death. God propels His people of faith toward a new obligation—life according to the Spirit. No longer bound by fleshly desires, believers experience a whole new way of life opening before them. **The Holy Spirit empowers God's children to live holy lives.** How will you embrace this truth as God's gracious gift to you?

Freedom in the Spirit – Romans 8:1-11

Paul's use of the word "therefore" introduces a pivot within his letter. Up to this point, while introducing grace and salvation since the middle of chapter 3, Paul had stressed in chapter 7 that humanity's sin nature is harbored in every person's heart. How can we move forward in faith, knowing that we deserve God's punishment and wrath? On our own, we can do nothing. *Nothing.* **For those in Christ, the Holy Spirit brings freedom from the grip of sin and the power to live a transformed life.**

A Believer's Reality: No Condemnation – 8:1

Sin twists human lives upside down and inside out. The sin that resulted in Paul's despairing cries in Romans 7:24 could have left us in ruin. **Instead, God's amazing provision leads to a glorious shout: "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."** Paul's exclamation reflects God's gracious heart and grand plan to redeem His people. Four great words in verse 1 proclaim God's gospel of grace to sinners:

- **"Therefore" connects Paul's explosive statement with all his previous teachings in Romans.** At the cross, God's sinless Son took sin's full weight of condemnation, deserved by every person. The Holy Spirit has applied God's work through Jesus Christ to all who believe the gospel. Therefore, Christians already experience the freedom of God's final verdict of no condemnation. Christ bore the full weight of sin's power, guilt, shame, and punishment to save all who would believe.
- **"Now" refers to a point in time and reflects the immediate change in relationship status that occurs upon belief in Christ.** Once, we stood condemned and separated from God. We deserved and awaited the wages our sin had earned: eternal death.[1] But now, because of Christ, God has declared believers righteous in Christ. By God's grace alone, through faith in Christ alone, all who believe enter a new life reconciled to God through Jesus's death and resurrection.
- **"No," translated as a simple negative in English, communicated a stronger exclamation in the Greek used by Paul.** Paul emphasized his point with a powerful "no." His shout of "no condemnation" would read as if bolded, underlined, capitalized, and italicized. No believers are condemned, nor can they ever be; condemnation of a believer is utterly impossible.
- **"Condemnation" is a legal term that can include a judge's verdict and the deserved punishment or sentencing of the person found guilty.** Apart from Christ, all people live under condemnation, unable to save themselves.[2] Many people suffer under a heavy burden of guilt and shame for past wrongdoings, cut off from God and rejected by those around them. Others believe they do not deserve condemnation, considering themselves basically good. The early chapters of Romans painstakingly proved that all people are guilty of sin, without excuse before God and rightly deserving of His wrath. Paul's declaration of a believer's freedom from deserved condemnation represents a shocking and amazing new reality for the believer. Sin has a powerful presence in this world and our lives, but God's grace has overcome its penalty and power. Believers are released from sin's crushing weight of guilt when they receive God's great gift of grace. With shame permanently removed, they belong to Him forever.

A Believer's Reality: God's Work Within – 8:2-4

Having proven moral standards and God's law are powerless to save, Paul reminded Rome's believers of the source of their true freedom: Only God can free sinners from sin's condemnation. Jesus's work on the cross and His indwelling Spirit within the hearts of His people are God's gracious gifts that transform their lives and eternal destiny.[3]

1. **Wages for sin:** John 3:18; Romans 5:12; 6:23
2. **Under sin:** Romans 3:9-21
3. **God's gift:** John 3:16-17

***The Trinity at Work (8:2-3)* – God's saving work involves each person of the Godhead: God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit.**[4] God's triune nature is on full display in verses 2-3. There is "no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus [the Son], because through Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit who gives life has set you free from the law of sin and death. For what the law was powerless to do because it was weakened by the flesh, God did by sending His own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh to be a sin offering. And so he condemned sin in the flesh."

God's triune divine nature is mysterious to us. He is one God in three eternal and equal persons who lovingly share one mind and will in all things, relating to one another in perfect unity and peace. **The Father, Son, and Spirit are distinct yet indivisible, working together to free God's people from condemnation.** God the Father sent God the Son to save sinners. Jesus was born as a human while remaining fully God and living a sinless life. Jesus's work on the cross placed the full weight of condemnation on His shoulders, not ours. Resurrected and ascended, Jesus proved His victory over death and sin and justifies all who trust Him for salvation. The Holy Spirit dwells within the hearts of His saved people. The Spirit's powerful transforming work enables believers to live righteously. All praise, honor, and glory belong to our triune God!

God not only declares believers without condemnation, He also enables them to live as new creations in Christ.

Righteous Requirements Met (8:3-4) – Only Jesus's substitutionary work can save sinners. Jesus fully met the law's righteous requirements on behalf of every sinner, and God transfers His perfect righteousness to everyone who comes to Him in faith. With believers declared righteous by faith, God works within His people to set them free from sin's power. God sets believers apart to worship and serve Him and grow in holiness. God not only declares believers without condemnation, He also enables them to live as new creations in Christ.[5] As Paul taught in Chapter 7, sanctification is the process by which the Holy Spirit makes a believer more like Christ. **Through the Holy Spirit, believers can exercise their freedom not to sin.**

Holiness: Justification's Goal – Justification by grace through faith upholds the law's demands for justice. According to the law, sin's penalty is death. Jesus died not to leave us in our sin but to save us from our sins,[6] lift our shame, free us from fear, and enable us to live holy lives.[7] Paul explained God's saving work in verses 3-4, noting Jesus's full but sinless humanity.[8] God sent "his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh." Jesus stepped into death, becoming sin's offering on our behalf.[9] He made justification possible for believers. **God justifies believers so holiness can permeate their daily reality.**[10]

Holiness: The Law's Demands Satisfied – The English phrase translated "live according to the Spirit" is more literally "walk according to the Spirit" in the original Greek. **God's Spirit directs the Christian on a path to increasingly reflect God's character.**[11] God's commands set the path's boundaries. Jesus freed believers from sin's curse to follow Him on this path. God condemned sin in the flesh "in order that the righteous requirements of the law might fully be met in us."

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4. **The Trinity:** 1 Peter 1:2
5. **New life:** John 3:5-8; 2 Corinthians 5:17
6. **Saved from sin:** Matthew 1:21
7. **Holy lives:** 1 Thessalonians 4:7-8
8. **Jesus's sinless humanity:** John 1:14; Hebrews 4:15
9. **Sin offering:** Romans 3:24-26
10. **Righteous requirements upheld:** Romans 3:31
11. **Reflect God's character:** Leviticus 19:2; Ephesians 4:24; 1 Peter 1:15-16

A Spirit-Led Life

The Doctrine of God the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit makes a believer's sanctification possible. Before his conversion, Paul thought himself fully capable of keeping God's law. Following his conversion, Paul realized God's standards reached higher and his own sinfulness extended further than he ever imagined. In despair over his sin, Paul learned that he could only overcome sin through God's grace in Jesus[1] and the Holy Spirit's power.[2] **Only the Holy Spirit empowers believers to break free from sin's allure.**

The Holy Spirit's presence abounds wherever the Lord Jesus Christ is preached and glorified and when people come to Him in true faith.[3] The Holy Spirit immediately indwells every Christian when they receive salvation in Jesus.[4] In fact, the Holy Spirit's conviction and regenerating work makes belief possible. This true baptism with the Holy Spirit occurs only once and is permanent. The New Testament, especially the book of Acts, also speaks of a "filling" of the Holy Spirit, which may occur repeatedly after the indwelling.[5] Increased spiritual power in ministry and faithful verbal witness to Jesus as the Savior characterize the Spirit's "filling." The Holy Spirit constantly works to draw people to Christ.

To deny the Holy Spirit's presence is to deny the triune nature of God Himself. A life void of the Holy Spirit is a life without God and His presence. Common blessings from God exist, such as sunshine and nature's beauty, but living apart from God's indwelling presence leaves lingering emptiness that only He can fill. Seeking only this world's pleasures brings a deadly void, leading downward into sin's unsatisfying spiral. **Disregarding the Holy Spirit and His work ultimately brings tragic results because life in the flesh is death itself.**

The Holy Spirit dwells within everyone who truly believes in Jesus Christ as their Lord and Savior. Unseen by the human eye, the Holy Spirit is believers' counselor, comforter, and advocate, who regenerates and transforms, grants assurance of salvation, and empowers them to serve and witness. Those who walk according to the Spirit experience life and peace. The Holy Spirit empowers God's people to resist sin's temptations. When their sin quenches or grieves the Holy Spirit, Christ offers forgiveness.[6] The Holy Spirit works to produce abundant life in believers through times of worship, prayer, and conviction of sin. The Holy Spirit grows Christ's followers in faith and deepens their love for God.[7]

1. **God's grace:** Romans 5:20-21; 7:25
2. **Power over sin:** Romans 8:13; Galatians 5:16
3. **Holy Spirit at work:** John 15:26; 16:7-15
4. **Indwelling Holy Spirit:** 1 Corinthians 6:19; 12:13
5. **Filling of the Holy Spirit:** Acts 2:4; 4:8, 31; Ephesians 5:18
6. **Sin grieves the Spirit:** Ephesians 4:30; 1 Thessalonians 5:19; 1 John 1:9
7. **Growth through the Spirit:** John 14:15-21; Romans 8:10-11, 14-16; 2 Corinthians 3:17-18; Galatians 5:16-25; Ephesians 3:16-19; 5:18-21

How can the law's righteous requirements be met in any person? The Holy Spirit makes this possible. Jesus's death meets the law's demands for justice, and the Spirit directs a believer's life to meet the law's demands for righteousness. **By the Spirit's liberating power, believers experience freedom from sin's captivity with changed lives that honor Christ.**

A Believer's Mindset – 8:5-11

What differentiates God's people from the unsaved? In Romans 5, Paul explained death through Adam and life through Christ. **Romans 8 contrasts life in the flesh with life in the Spirit.** Paul began his explanation by addressing the mindset of unbelievers and believers.

***Flesh Versus Spirit (8:5-8)* – Paul stated that those who live according to the flesh have minds "set on what the flesh desires."** Flesh, in this case, means more than simply the sins of the body. Given over to every sinful whim, minds set on the flesh oppose and rebel against God.

On the other hand, a true believer's mind is "set on what the Spirit desires." While God's standards remain unattainable through human effort, God's people desire and pursue Christlike living. God sent His Son to the cross and gave His Spirit to His people so they might meet the law's demands through union with Christ and grow in righteous living. This is God's desire for every believer.[12]

In verses 6-8, Paul further defined what controls people's minds. The mind governed by the flesh is death itself. Hostile to God, this mind does not and cannot submit to God's law nor please God in any way. **The mind governed by the Spirit, however, gains life and peace.** People with this mindset humbly seek to follow God and please Him in all they say and do.

***The Realm of the Spirit (8:9-11)* – Paul moved from the mind set on the Spirit to living in the realm of the Spirit: "You, however, are not in the realm of the flesh but are in the realm of the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God lives in you."** Those who do not have the Spirit of God do not belong to Christ. Those who live in the Spirit's realm experience unity with Christ. For believers, the time when sin and the flesh exerted unopposed dominion has ended. God alone accomplishes this through Jesus.

Because of sin's lingering presence in the world, every believer remains subject to physical death. Sickness, scars, and physical ailments reveal the seeds of death remaining in our bodies. But "if Christ is in you ... the Spirit gives life because of righteousness." **Not only does the Holy Spirit make believers alive to God, but they also find life in God's Word and through the Spirit's work in their lives.**

Each Christian's life points forward to physical resurrection and eternal life. Although physical death looms, believers will rise again: "If the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead is living in you, he who raised Christ from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies because of his Spirit who lives in you." **Because salvation is God's work and not our own, the new life a believer experiences now assures the resurrection life God has promised.**

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12. God's desire for believers: Philippians 3:7-14

Life in the Spirit – Romans 8:12-17

Paul moved forward with another "therefore" that shifts toward a new responsibility for believers. The Holy Spirit joins God's people to Christ. They are delivered from God's condemnation and wrath. Believers now live in the realm of the Spirit with a new nature. Because of their new life, they have a new obligation and a new family.

A Believer's Obligation – 8:12-13

Paul taught that believers' former obligation to sin has been abolished; they should not go back to their sinful lifestyles. No longer living according to the flesh, they are called to put the body's misdeeds to death and live by the Spirit. **The Holy Spirit saves, empowers, and unites believers to Christ.** A believer owes nothing to sin and the flesh. Instead, our obligation is to God in Christ—to live in the Holy Spirit's power.[13]

A Believer's Family – 8:14-17

Paul added depth and richness to a believer's identity when he stated that only "those who are led by the Spirit of God are the children of God." Before, believers were "in Adam"; now, they are "in Christ."[14] Before, they were under condemnation; now, they are no longer condemned. Yet much more than a change of state, God considers every believer a part of His family—His own children. What an incomprehensible gift! How amazing that God would choose to call us His children! Being God's child involves living in dynamic relationship with the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit lives within every true child of God, leading them to be more like Christ.

The Holy Spirit brings about our adoption to sonship: God's children are those who love Him and listen to His Word. Jesus spoke clearly to His unbelieving opponents, saying, "The reason you do not hear is that you do not belong to God."[15] He clearly stated that not everyone is a member of God's family. No one inherits godliness from their parents.[16] But through His Spirit, God adopts everyone who believes in Jesus into His family. Paul said, "The Spirit you received does not make you slaves, so that you live in fear again; rather, the Spirit you received brought about your adoption to sonship." Women and enslaved people in Rome had many reasons to fear neglect, abandonment, or mistreatment. Paul's use of "sonship" proclaims that all God's children can live without fear because they possess full rights and status as sons. Even more, believers become co-heirs with Christ and receive every good and perfect heavenly gift, including eternal life![17]

The Holy Spirit grants assurance that God is our "*Abba,* Father." The ability to call God our Father goes back to Jesus's teachings. When His disciples prayed, Jesus taught them to call on God as their Father.[18] The night before the cross, Jesus prayed, "*Abba,* Father ... take this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will."[19] God's people can expect an intimate relationship with God and His comforting care even in hardships and suffering.[20]

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13. **Live for God:** Romans 6:12-14
14. **In Adam, in Christ:** Romans 5:12-21
15. **Jesus's words to unbelievers:** John 8:47
16. **No godliness:** John 1:12-13
17. **Spiritual blessings:** Ephesians 1:3-14
18. **God our Father:** Matthew 6:8-15
19. **Take this cup:** Mark 14:36
20. **Hardship and suffering:** Matthew 10:29-31; Hebrews 12:3-11

The Holy Spirit testifies with our Spirit that we belong to God's family. The Holy Spirit taught believers in Rome and teaches God's children across the globe today. God not only adopts all believers as His children, He also takes an unimaginable next step to make us His heirs—co-heirs with Christ. Though this life overflows with God's many blessings, adoption does not promise believers earthly riches or freedom from suffering. Life's many challenges lead God's children to persevere as His heirs. We grow to be like Christ as we share in His sufferings. Christlikeness comes not through the suffering itself but as the Holy Spirit sanctifies us and leads us to trust God. All God's children will share Christ's glory and live as His holy people forever.[21] The Holy Spirit empowers God's children to live holy lives.

Take to Heart

Hold Fast

Paul's despairing wail in Chapter 7 bursts into his glorious declaration of complete freedom in Chapter 8: "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus." **Jesus took our condemnation to the cross and buried it in the tomb forever.** He rose in victory so that by His Spirit we might live free from sin's condemnation of death and experience life and peace. Jesus took on sinful flesh, lived without sin, and fulfilled the law's requirement on our behalf. As a result, all who believe in Christ find God's righteous requirements of the law fully satisfied and move forward living according to the Spirit, not in the deadness of sin. We celebrate Easter once a year, yet believers live in the freedom won by Jesus's resurrection each day.

An obligation comes with believers' newfound freedom: "Therefore, brothers and sisters, we have an obligation—but it is not to the flesh, to live according to it." A believer's obligation is to turn from the flesh and choose to live according to the Spirit. This obligation grows out of gratitude for what God's amazing grace has accomplished for us. It is not a response to the law but to a relationship that is rooted in appreciation for God's love toward us. Fleshly desires are put to death because Christ defeated sin on the cross. Any who choose to live by the flesh will die, but those who choose life in the Spirit will live. Not only do believers experience victory over sin and death, but they also receive an unimaginable gift. Those led by the Spirit become God's children—adopted into His family as co-heirs with Christ. Sharing in Christ's suffering means believers share in His glory for all eternity. What a gift indeed!

Apply It

How deeply have you pondered Paul's breathtaking exclamation of "no condemnation"? These two words communicate gifts we can scarcely describe. Your past and present sins bring no accusation, verdict of guilt, or sentence of shame. Instead, Christ sets believers free from condemnation, free from sin's captivity, and free from God's wrath that leads to death. **In Christ, believers are freed to live for God and empowered by His Spirit to do so.** What emotions stir in your heart as you meditate on Romans 8:1? Freely express your gratitude to Christ Jesus and embrace His Holy Spirit's transformational power. Have you taken the pivotal first step—faith in Jesus? If not, today is that day for you. Choose life in the Spirit!

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21. Christ's glory: Romans 8:29; 1 John 3:1-3

Once captive to sin and death, those who believe are slaves no more; they carry no obligation whatsoever to sin or their fleshly desires. Sin's appeal no longer controls us. Instead, our new obligation and devotion are to live according to the Spirit, who gives strength to say no to sin's deceit and manipulation. In God's strength, we can stand against sin's relentless beckoning. We can walk away from gossip. We can turn from anger or angry words. We can cry for help when temptation lures us. What sin still has a hold on your life? When will you take hold of the Holy Spirit's gift and fully embrace your freedom from condemnation, living a life of peace that God intends for you?

The Holy Spirit empowers believers to follow Christ and be led by Him.[22] We cannot do this in our own strength. The Holy Spirit creates godly desires within us and teaches us to rely on God's enabling, not our own fortitude.[23] For God's people, holiness is far more than a good idea or reasonable goal. If you are a believer in Jesus Christ, holiness is your destiny.[24] God created you to live with Christ forever, indwelt by His Spirit. He set you apart and placed you on the path of holiness to glorify Him and enjoy His presence. As you grasp God's grace that has set you free from sin's power, He will multiply your joy as He works out His salvation in you. How will you respond to the Spirit's transforming work?

This passage describes God's beautiful path for His children that incorporates His gift of adoption. God welcomes believers as His children. Rather than a license to sin, freedom from condemnation extends God's open call to repentance. He longs for His children to turn to Him and receive forgiveness. He invites us to step into His family as His adopted heirs. Our Father welcomes us as we eagerly approach Him. Picture the reality of your holy Father looking upon you from heaven and declaring, "That's my child!" In what ways will you express your love to God, who lavishes His love upon you as your Father?[25] How can we adequately thank our God? All praise be to God our Father, Jesus our Savior, and the Holy Spirit our guide! May praise to Him ring out today and throughout all eternity!

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22. **Follow Jesus:** Hebrews 12:1-3
23. **Seeking God's will:** Philippians 2:13
24. **Holiness:** Romans 8:29
25. **God our Father:** Matthew 6:8-15

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